Japan will have to move beyond its comfort zone to come to terms with the realities of Asia. Dealing with an India is best done through bilateral diplomacy. Generating understanding of developments key to its welfare would surely come from extending support for similar Indian concerns. While partnering in an effort to reform the UN, it will also have to engage vigorously those that resist change. On India's side, expectations must be tempered by a recognition that Japan has its own compulsions and culture. While the two countries have much going for them in expanding their relationship, there is no automaticity about it. This caution is warranted because there is sometimes an assumption that Japan would see the world in terms similar to us. The fact is that we are dealing with a more deliberative society that seeks greater consensus to make decisions.

The challenges are, however, not limited to the different temperament of our societies. Expanding business is without doubt the most important goal. On the Indian side, there has to be a constant improvement of the enabling environment, a specific focus on Japanese requirements and an aggressive utilization of instruments that have been put in place. None of this is a given in a polity where the tendency has often been to benchmark itself against its own past. Indians will have to display some of the perseverance that is normally associated with Japan. On the Japanese side, there has to be more risk-taking and a stronger commitment to scale up. The longer the delay in its entry or expansion, the higher will be the cost. Rather than wait for India to produce the ideal conditions to do business, Japanese companies must take more initiative to shape it themselves. To that extent, they need to imbibe some Indian traits that would help them take the plunge.

In the political arena, India and Japan may both hedge, but not necessarily on the same issues and to the same degree. Neither has an interest in closing any option in a multipolar world, especially those in the immediate neighbourhood. How to execute that in real life without doubting each other will need attention. Even on an issue like connectivity, the compulsions of the two nations are somewhat different. A continuous dialogue is necessary, especially on issues of less convergence. As the one that is more deeply embedded in the entrenched order, Japan would also have to factor in new balances and shifts of influence. Its ability to look beyond established